

Clermont County Township Association Regular Meeting Minutes

Date: 08/20/2026

Host: Union Township

Call to Order: Meeting called to order at 6:08 PM by Allen Freeman with the following CCTA Officers & Active Members in attendance:

Batavia Township:

Trustee Danielle Wessel

Goshen Township:

Trustee / CCTA Vice-President Bob Hausermann

Ohio Township:

Trustee Keith Vogelsang

Trustee Scott Wolf

Pierce Township:

Trustee / CCTA President Allen Freeman

Union Township:

Trustee John Becker

Fiscal Officer Ron Campbell

Washington Township:

Trustee Dennis Cooper

Wayne Township:

Trustee Teresa Hinnners

Williamsburg Township:

Trustee Gary Jordan

Trustee Charlie Maklem

And CCTA Secretary/Treasurer Shelby Baird

Mr. Freeman welcomed everyone to the meeting. A prayer was offered by Bob McGee. County Commissioner David Painter led those present in the recitation of the Pledge of Allegiance.

Mr. Freeman invited everyone to grab some dinner. Meeting resumed approximately 6:30 PM. Mr. Freeman gave a brief overview of some items that we need to try to settle this evening, covering the question of the Christmas party and fundraising again. And shared the thought that we should consider possibly holding the October meeting somewhere other than with the Clermont County Sheriff to hold a roundtable on economic development. He suggested that we could decide if we wanted to save our discussion items for after our guest speaker or move through them quickly now.

Mr. Cooper asked for clarification about who would host the October meeting if we did not have it at the Clermont County Sheriff's office. Mr. Freeman stated that if we did not have the meeting with the Sheriff that Pierce Township would host it, but that statement shouldn't preclude having another township host ... just that Pierce Township is a fallback option.

Ms. Hinnners stated she would prefer if we heard from the guest speaker now. Mr. Freeman introduced the guest speaker who was attending via Zoom, Mr. Pete Griggs, Attorney and Principal at BJG Law.

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Mr. Griggs took the floor and hosted an open discussion about matters pertaining to township zoning, and particularly hyper-scale data centers. At the conclusion of Mr. Griggs' discussion and Q&A, Mr. Freeman returned to the CCTA's regular business.

Discussion followed from Mr. Griggs' presentation about townships' individual moratoriums on data centers. Mr. Freeman put some perspective on what we should take away from that presentation, and to highlight the actions townships can be taking to get ahead of the question as well as more detail about how to think strategically how data centers could be negotiated to be beneficial. He drew similarities to how the solar projects were in the beginning when there were strong incentives, perceivable as a moderately predatory race.

Commissioner David Painter provided some details and thoughts on the intricacies of economic development, and the amount of investment it takes to attract large economic development projects. He recommends that townships evaluate properties based on the status of the type of properties that could support a project of this nature, thinking about brownfield properties for example or properties that may have restrictive covenants against residential development, and think about how those properties could be purposed to attract particular types of development that could bring long term economic benefits to the township.

Mr. Painter also encouraged townships to consider abatements and other incentives at the state level that could drive data center projects, and about how a port authority could navigate the issues without needing townships to sign NDAs.

Mr. Freeman reiterated that if there was one key takeaway from the data center discussion, it is that it is a very complex issue and that townships need to use resources that may be available outside of their own staff by leveraging the tools and staff that the Clermont County Community and Economic Development department has. Reach out to other townships and pick their brains and ask how they navigated the issues. Townships don't have to feel that they're out there on their own.

Charlie Maklem shared some feedback about Williamsburg Township's experiences with the Nestlé Purina plant, and how they learned and leveraged those outside resources due to their own small staff. He also pointed out that one thing he learned is that these projects are all unique.

The discussion continued about how unique township communities and their cultures differ, and that while some enjoy a simpler way of life, still others enjoy modernization and growth along with access to public infrastructure resources.

Mr. Freeman turned to the CCTA's meeting calendar for the rest of the year. We have the Clermont County Engineer's meeting coming up next month, and we generally have the Sheriff's office the month after that. While we were talking about that, he asked the members if they had any further thoughts about moving, vacating, or maybe just not having the October meeting this year. Danielle Wessel asked what the Sheriff's meeting usually entails. Mr. Freeman replied that they usually do a presentation, and it's generally nice. Commissioner Painter shared that the Sheriff does have a new facility, along with their new SAFE group that does a whole different type of investigation. Mr. Freeman shared that last

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year we toured the new facility, and Mr. Painter shared that they've made some additional improvements and fully moved into the new facility.

Mr. Freeman continued that we could go forward with the October meeting as planned, or we could consider putting together an economic development roundtable in its place. He reminded the CCTA that Kris McClintock has wanted for some time to make a presentation at one of the CCTA meetings, and that it could align well with that purpose. Some members stated that it could also align with the November meeting in Williamsburg Township. Mr. Freeman stated that we could keep the schedule as is and have the economic development roundtable in November; essentially that we would schedule it however the membership wants.

Ms. Wessel stated that she would like to see us still do the October meeting with the Sheriff and have the economic development roundtable at the November meeting. Mr. Freeman said that would be ok and we will set up the economic development roundtable along with the November meeting in Williamsburg.

Commissioner Painter also shared that next week is the County Commissioners Association's Summer Symposium in Hamilton County, and that attendees don't have to register for the entire symposium but if there is a particular presentation that one sees on the schedule it is possible to pay just for that particular presentation only. Mr. Freeman asked Mr. Painter if he could get that information to Mr. Baird, and we can add it to our webpage. Mr. Baird reminded the group that adding things like that to our webpage is quite difficult, so it would be better to just email the information to the membership. Mr. Painter said they could just add the info to the County's website and then we can just go there to get the information. Mr. Baird asked if the information is posted to the County's website that they could have someone email him the link to share the location to the CCTA membership by email.

Mr. Cooper then informed the group that Washington Township's Fiscal Officer's husband recently passed away. Mr. Freeman suggested that we should send a card and flowers to Ms. Dufau. Mr. Painter also reminded the group that former Commissioner Humphrey was just laid to rest. Mr. Freeman shared an anecdote about Mr. Humphrey's work ethic.

Ms. Wessel raised a question about the CCTA's website, but Mr. Freeman said that we would come back to that but first we needed to answer the question about sending flowers to Ms. Dufau, and if we needed to set a budget for that purpose. Teresa Hinnars moved to purchase the flower arrangement and have it delivered with a purchase not to exceed \$50, seconded by Tom Peck. Motion carried without opposition. Mr. Freeman instructed Mr. Baird that the two would get together to finalize that order. Mr. Baird asked Dennis Cooper where the services would be so he can send the flowers. Mr. Cooper said they would be held at Calvary.

Mr. Freeman then recognized Ms. Wessel's question about the website. Ms. Wessel re-stated the question that the CCTA has a website, and it's paid for, but we don't use it. Mr. Freeman replied that yes, we have the website, but it is difficult to manage. Mr. Freeman stated that it's a question we're going to have to discuss further, maybe find a way that we can move it to another platform. But if it makes it

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easier, since Mr. Baird is the one that uses it more than anyone, he asked for his feedback on the website.

Mr. Baird informed the group that he had almost put it on the agenda for the Secretary's report to bring it for discussion but held off because he's been working on preparing a report on that subject but didn't have it for tonight's meeting. He's been doing some analysis on the website and shared that there are options to host what we have right now at no, or little, cost. Right now, the website is costing the CCTA right around \$300 every two years to be hosted where it is as it was when handed over to him. As the website sits, to include having an ability to have a simple content management ability to add information to the website without needing to do manual code editing could be accomplished at no cost, or very low cost. The domain registration would still have a cost, but the website itself could be no cost. That was one option he'd looked at, but if we wanted to have something a little more robust, we could probably accomplish that within the same cost we are accustomed to.

Mr. Baird shared that he would like to see the CCTA be able to get more out of their website, to be able to publish blog posts and the like, to be able to get information out to the group and that it is simply beyond the capability of the current website as it has been architected.

Mr. Freeman asked the members if they thought it would be ok for Mr. Baird, at the next board meeting even though it is going to be at the Engineer's office, to prepare and bring some recommendations for discussion. Mr. Baird stated that we are going to have a renewal next May and that he was going to recommend that we do not plan for that renewal. It's far enough away that it gives us time to be able to find a more viable replacement, and that a new solution would also give us an SSL certificate for the website.

Mr. Baird added that without an SSL certificate, most modern browsers will not show the site, which is a problem that has been on his mind to resolve. He stated that he would bring his report and some information on it to the next meeting.

Mr. Baird thanked a member for the offer of help with evaluating and planning, and shared that it's always good to put heads together and get somebody else's opinion rather than doing things completely alone.

Dennis Cooper raised a question on ORC 9.64 and how other townships are complying with that. Are other townships just adopting a policy, and stating it is now the policy? Mr. Freeman replied that Pierce Township adopted a policy, and due to recent events, they are redoing their website at present. Mr. Cooper reported that Washington Township's Fire Chief raised the issue with priority that they need to do something.

Mr. Freeman shared that in the process of updating their website, they are also working and evaluating all their systems and working on the cybersecurity plan in that process. Mr. Cooper asked if Pierce Township hired a consultant to help with this. Mr. Freeman said yes, but they'd had to do it anyway, so they are accomplishing multiple goals. Mr. Cooper asked if other townships had hired assistance for

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achieving compliance. Denise Maklem, Jackson Township Administrator, replied that her township had not and that she'd done that work herself.

Mr. Cooper also asked for confirmation of the location of the September meeting with the County Engineer. Mr. Freeman said that nothing had been officially sent by the Engineer, but that he believes the meeting will be at the new Highway Operations Center again this year.

Karen Swartz, Batavia Township Administrator, reminded everyone that the OTA has a lot of resources on their website. Batavia Township was in the process of redoing their website as well.

Mr. Cooper followed up with a question if anyone had an idea of what getting help with ORC 9.64 compliance might cost. Mr. Freeman replied that it depends a lot on the firm that is picked. Mr. Baird recommended that Mr. Cooper might consider reaching out to SWOCA to discuss their offerings and shared his experiences with opening discussions with them. Mr. Baird committed to send SWOCA's contact info to Mr. Cooper.

Mr. Freeman recapped that the September meeting was going to be with the Clermont County Engineer, and then our October meeting will be the Sheriff as usual, and the roundtable in November in Williamsburg. Mr. Freeman then asked if we still wanted to consider having a Christmas party, and whether we want to consider having it again at the Barn. An open discussion about venue, and availability followed, and that it would have to be on a Monday.

Mr. Freeman said he would gather some more info about the Barn and bring info back for discussion at the September meeting. Mr. Freeman asked if there was anything else those present would like to share or discuss. Mr. Cooper moved to adjourn the meeting.

Ron Campbell advised everyone to check for a State Auditor's bulletin regarding ORC 9.64. Union Township's audit had just been completed, and they are now working to implement MFA by way of RSA fobs, which cost roughly \$3,000 per 20 count and they need over 160, which is required for all employees. Prior to the audit they had implemented the MFA solution for all their high-level systems, but the Auditor stated that all employees are required to use MFA for their logins. Mr. Campbell shared that they had just received their report, and shortly thereafter the Auditor released a bulletin about MFA. Mr. Campbell just advised that other townships start planning because the requirement is coming.

Mr. Baird reminded Mr. Freeman to thank Union Township for their hospitality this evening. Mr. Campbell reminded everyone that this evening's dinner was catered by Noble Chicken. Mr. Freeman thanked Union Township again for providing dinner this evening.

Michael Wright shared his opinion that we need to think constructively about data centers and think of them as a somewhat necessary evil. Mr. Freeman agreed that we must find a way to balance and find the best benefits for our respective communities.

Mr. Freeman reminded that we did have a motion to adjourn on the floor and asked for a second. Tom Peck seconded. Meeting adjourned at 7:34 PM.